THE ALPHA REPORT

2026 NCAA Men's Tournament | Monte Carlo Simulation (50,000 runs) | 7-Feature Logistic Regression + KenPom SOS Model

SECTION 1 — THE CHAMPION

MODEL'S PICK: (1) Duke — 37.9% Championship Probability

Duke emerges as the model's highest-probability champion from 50,000 Monte Carlo simulations. Their dominance is driven by the strongest composite four-factor profile in the 2026 tournament field, reinforced by a #1 KenPom adjusted efficiency ranking (fully strength-of-schedule-adjusted). The model projects Duke to reach the Sweet 16 in **91.3%** of simulations, the Final Four in **72.1%**, and the national championship game in a majority of runs. Duke's combination of elite shooting efficiency, defensive stifling, and dominant rebounding creates a statistical profile that no other team in this field can match. Their SOS-adjusted season eFG% of **58.5%** ranks among the nation's elite, while their KenPom (POM) ranking — the gold standard of strength-of-schedule-adjusted efficiency — confirms them as the highest-rated team in the 2026 field with a +38.88 AdjEM.

Round	R32	Sweet 16	Elite 8	Final Four	Champion
Probability	**99.2%**	**91.3%**	**83.2%**	**72.1%**	**37.9%**

SECTION 2 — THE CINDERELLA

MODEL'S PICK: (11) Miami (OHIO) — 16.9% Sweet 16 | 0.1% Championship Probability

Miami (OHIO) (seed 11) is the model's top Cinderella candidate, advancing to the Sweet 16 in **16.9%** of all simulations — an extraordinary figure for a double-digit seed. This team's four-factor efficiency profile is statistically superior to their higher-seeded first-round opponent, a discrepancy the model identifies and exploits.

(11) Miami (OHIO) advances to the Sweet 16 in 16.9% of simulations. Round 1 matchup: (11) Miami (OHIO) vs (6) Tennessee. Four-factor comparison — eFG: 57.6% vs 52.4%; TOV%: 13.6 vs 15.9; ORB%: 42.8% vs 62.7%; FTR: 0.411 vs 0.398. Key matchup edges: shooting edge: Miami (OHIO) eFG 57.6% vs Tennessee 52.4% (+5.2pp).

SECTION 3 — THE FADE

FADE THIS TEAM: (4) Kansas — Only 85.5% R32 Probability | 37.2% Sweet 16

Kansas (seed 4) is the model's most vulnerable top-four seed. A 85.5% Round of 32 probability means the model projects a **14.4% chance of a Round 1 upset** — a significant red flag for a seed that carries heavy public expectations. This is not simply a product of bracket placement; the team's four-factor efficiency profile contains measurable weaknesses that their first-round opponent can exploit. The public overvalues this team's seeding while the model sees real statistical vulnerability.

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Value analysis: Simulated championship probability 0.04% vs seed-average historical expectation
2.20% — the model prices this team at 0.02× their historical seed baseline.
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SECTION 4 — THE CONTRARIAN PICK (Part D)

CONTRARIAN MATCHUP: (8) Clemson vs (9) Iowa | Model disagrees with public by 16.0 percentage points

The 2026 tournament's clearest market inefficiency is **(8) Clemson vs (9) Iowa**. The public — citing seeding and name recognition — makes **(8) Clemson** a **57%** favorite. Our model disagrees sharply: it gives **(8) Clemson** only **41.0%** win probability, a **16.0 percentage point gap** that far exceeds the 15-point threshold for a meaningful market divergence.

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Statistical basis: (8) Clemson eFG=53.6%, TOV%=13.0, ORB%=50.3%, FTR=0.380 vs (9) Iowa eFG=56.8%,
TOV%=13.9, ORB%=53.6%, FTR=0.357.
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Key edges driving the model's contrarian view: **(9) Iowa** holds a **+3.2pp shooting efficiency advantage** (eFG), a **+3.3pp offensive rebounding edge**, and forces their opponent into higher turnover rates (opponent TOV% differential: -0.9). The public overvalues **(8) Clemson**'s seeding. The model sees their statistical weakness and prices the upset at **59.0%** — roughly 1.4× higher than market implied probability.

Four-Factor Comparison:

Metric	(8) Clemson	(9) Iowa	Edge
eFG%	53.6%	56.8%	+(9) Iowa
TOV%	13.0	13.9	+(8) Clemson
ORB%	50.3%	53.6%	+(9) Iowa
FTR	0.380	0.357	+(8) Clemson

Generated: ECE 3308 — Live Fire Exercise | Monte Carlo engine: 50,000 simulations | Model: 6-feature logistic regression trained on 120,264 historical tournament matchups | Data: Kaggle March Machine Learning Mania 2026